saw these monoliths as connected with an important Buddhist king of past times.

But coming back to Xuanzang: in addition to Ashokan pillars his account preserves vivid memories and graphic stories about stupas constructed by ‘Ashoka Raja’. Stupas that he believes were built by Ashoka are among the shrines he documents, all the way from Gandhara to the Gangetic plains. Almost inevitably, from this pilgrim’s progress through India it would seem that most stupas commemorated places relating to incidents in the Buddha’s life. Nagarhara is an example of this. Here a carved stone stupa ‘built by Ashoka Raja’ was said to stand, marking the place where ‘Sakya, when a Bodhisattva’ had met the Dipankara Buddha.[35] Again, an Ashoka stupa, he tells us, stood between the ‘Mo-su’ sangharama and the ‘Shan-ni-lo-shi’ valley. In a clear reference to the Sibi Jataka, he asserts that this was where in a previous birth the future Buddha was said to have chopped up his own body into pieces so as ‘to redeem a dove from the power of a hawk’.[36] Then there are the stupas that Xuanzang describes as having been opened up by Ashoka to remove and redistribute the relics they contained. The Vaishali stupa was one such, and to authenticate the event he cites Indian texts which stated that ‘In this stupa there was first a quantity of relics equal to a “hoh” (ten pecks). Asoka-raja opening it, took away nine-tenths of the whole, leaving only one-tenth behind.’[37] He tells us that this was something only Ashoka could have done. Apparently, after Ashoka ‘there was a king of the country who wished again to open the stupa, but at the moment when he began to do so, the earth trembled, and he dared not proceed to open (the stupa).’[38]

Finally, there were those rare spots where Asoka appears to have commemorated people and incidents in his own lifetime. Outside Taxila, for instance, Xuanzang believes he built a stupa which marked the place where Kunala was blinded on the orders of his unprincipled stepmother; and ‘when the blind pray to it (or before it) with fervent faith, many of them